

Lesson on the Holy Trinity

By Dn Yonnas · Holy Trinity · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

An introduction to the Church's confession of one God in three Persons, built on the Nicene Creed. The lesson explains one divine Nature and three distinct Persons, the meaning of Unbegotten, Begotten, and Proceeding, the 'Two Hands of God' teaching of St. Irenaeus, and the Fathers' analogy of fire — always with the reminder that every analogy falls short of the Mystery.

Lesson Objectives

- Confess one God in three Persons according to the Nicene Creed
- Explain the eternal distinctions: the Father unbegotten, the Son begotten, the Holy Spirit proceeding
- Use the Fathers' analogies (fire, the spoken word) while understanding their limits

Key Bible Verses

Matthew 28:19 — "baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit"

John 10:30 — "I and My Father are one."

Matthew 3:16–17 — the revelation of the Trinity at the Jordan

Main Teaching Points

- There is one Divine Nature (Essence) — indivisible and shared fully by the three Persons
- The Persons are distinguished only by their eternal relationships, never by rank or time
- The Son is eternally begotten of the Father, as a word comes forth from the mind
- The Holy Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father — not created, not begotten
- The Son and the Spirit are the 'Two Hands' of the Father in creation and salvation (St. Irenaeus)
- Unified without confusion, distinguished without separation — the Tewahedo mystery

Key Terms

- **Essence (Nature)** — The shared divine substance of God — what makes God, God. There is only one, indivisible.
- **Unbegotten** — The Father's personal property: He is the Source (Arche), proceeding from no one.
- **Begotten** — The Son's eternal relationship to the Father — coming forth as a word from the mind, outside of time, never created.
- **Proceeding** — The Holy Spirit's eternal relationship to the Father — not created, not begotten, eternally proceeding.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why do we say analogies like fire can help us but never fully explain the Trinity?
- What is the difference between 'begotten' and 'created'? Why does it matter?
- How does the Baptism of Christ at the Jordan reveal the three Persons?

Glory be to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen.